NETHERBLOOM

Book of Remembrance



The King on the Barge

The old grave-texts told the dead: do not drink from Lethe; find the spring of Memory. This Book is that spring.

THE SOUL OF THIS BOOK

The King on the Barge

A crown carried long after the kingdom fell.

He was a boy when he drew a sword that no one else could move, and a king before he was a man. For years he won every battle he rode to. He built a hall with a round table so that no knight would sit higher than another, and he believed, because he was young, that a fair table would make a fair world.

The sword he carried into those battles was not his. A hand clothed in white had risen from a lake and lent it to him, and he had promised it would go back to the water when his work was done. He meant to keep that promise. There was always one more war first.

His dearest friend was the best of his knights, and his friend loved the queen, and the queen loved his friend, more honestly than either of them loved him. He knew it long before he let himself know it. When at last it came out, the fellowship of the table broke into halves, then quarters, then into men killing each other on a field of his own making. He held the line long after the line was lost. At the end of that day only a handful were standing, and he was not among them.

They laid him on a black barge with three veiled women at the prow and pushed him out into the mist. On that barge he forgave them both, his friend and his queen, too late to tell either of them. The sword was never returned to the lake. He still wears the crown, and it grows heavier every year. The old ferryman would not take him: a king, he says, pays in debts, and this one has not paid.



What the Ferrymen know

His companions still answer when he calls: while he crosses, a Mantle costs only 2 Light. But his fellowship was always fragile. A Fracture strips the Mantle from the Ferryman who caused it, as his round table was once stripped bare, one empty chair at a time.

Twist: Mantles cost 2 Light. A Fracture strips the Mantle of the player who caused it.

Key Memory: *the hand that rose from the lake to give me a sword*



Keeping the Book

The Book has one page per Reach: page I, *Who I Was* (Reach I); page II, *What I Did* (Reach II); page III, *What I Carry* (Reach III). Each page has four slots, **Place**, **Person**, **Deed** and **Feeling**, which complete a sentence about the soul's life.

Inscribing. When a card Resonates, you may inscribe it if the slot shown on the card is still empty on the page of the Reach the soul is in. A **Key Memory** may be inscribed whenever it is played face up, Resonating or not. To inscribe, put the card in its slot with photo corners instead of discarding it; it stays there for the rest of the game. Oblivion cards and Burned cards cannot be inscribed.

Page rewards. Each page pays a small reward for each pair of neighbouring slots: **Place + Person**, **Person + Deed** and **Deed + Feeling**. When an inscription fills the second slot of a pair, do that pair's reward at once. One card can complete two pairs (a Person inscribed next to a Place and a Deed): do both. Each reward happens once per page; tick its box in the Book. The rewards are printed on each page:

Chapter Blessing. When all 4 slots of a page are filled (3 for the Garland Girl), the page also gives one Chapter Blessing at once (only once per page). The Blessing is not chosen. Check these in order and do the first one that is possible:

If the soul has at least one Fracture: remove 1 Fracture (from the highest well).

Otherwise, if any space has Black Water: remove the Black Water token closest ahead of the soul from the game.

Otherwise, if the forgotten pile has any cards: move the newest forgotten card to the discard pile.

Otherwise nothing happens.

Tuck an inscribed card into the well for its slot: slide its four corners into the photo corners. Slide it out again to reuse the card next game.

I · Who I Was

I was born near...



I loved...



I once...



and ever since I have carried...



☐ PLACE + PERSON
Place 1 Root.

☐ PERSON + DEED
Bloom 1 Root.

☐ DEED + FEELING
Gain 2 Light.

☐ Chapter Blessing (full page)

Keepsakes ☐ ☐ ☐

II · What I Did

At...



before...



I...



The price was...



☐ PLACE + PERSON
Banish the nearest Shade.

☐ PERSON + DEED
Drain the nearest Black Water.

☐ DEED + FEELING
Untie 1 knot on the fullest thread (if tied, you choose).

☐ Chapter Blessing (full page)

Keepsakes ☐ ☐ ☐

III · What I Carry

I go now, leaving...



forgiving...



unable to undo the day I...



holding only...



☐ PLACE + PERSON
Return the newest forgotten card to the discard pile.

☐ PERSON + DEED
Mend 1 Fracture.

☐ DEED + FEELING
The soul steps forward now, if the next space is Lit.

☐ Chapter Blessing (full page)

Keepsakes ☐ ☐ ☐

The Far Shore

At the Far Shore the Keeper lifts the veil and offers the cup. What the soul remembers decides how it drinks.

- ☐ **Inscribed in the Book**: the soul crosses remembering what mattered most.
- ☐ **In the forgotten pile**: the soul crosses without it, lighter and emptier.
- ☐ **Anywhere else** (deck, a hand or the discard pile): it was never spoken, and the soul crosses with it unsaid.

Then read the Book aloud, page by page, even after a loss. Empty slots are read as "...but this, the river has taken".

FERRYMEN _____ LANTERN _____ DATE _____



NETHERBLOOM

RALPH LAUXIE